

Personas

Overview

This document covers the definition and description of personas for the Animal Adoption Management System under six roles (Adopter / Shelter Staff / Veterinarian / Volunteer / Donor / Admin).

It persona creation follows the UXPressia guide and is grounded in real user research from community sources.

Framework: uxpressia.com/blog/how-to-create-persona-guide-examples

Each persona is built in three stages:

- Stage 1 — Research: pain points collected from Reddit communities & online articles
- Stage 2 — Scales: behavioral axes defined to map each persona's position
- Stage 3 — Persona card: filled in by you based on research and judgement

1. User Roles

The system supports six distinct user roles, each with a dedicated interface and permission set.

 Adopter	
Description	<i>A general member of the public looking to adopt a pet. They browse available animals, submit adoption applications, track their status, and schedule shelter visits.</i>
Goals	• Find the right pet quickly using advanced filters (species, breed, age, location) • Save and revisit animals of interest via a favorites list • Submit and track adoption applications in one place • Schedule in-person or virtual meet-and-greets with animals

 Shelter Staff	
Description	<i>Employees of a shelter branch responsible for managing day-to-day operations including animal intake, adoption processing, volunteer coordination, and events.</i>
Goals	• Manage animal profiles and keep listings accurate and up to date • Review, approve, or decline adoption applications efficiently • Coordinate volunteers and assign tasks • Organise fundraising events and community outreach programs • Track donations received by the shelter • Maintain medical records and vaccination history for each animal



Veterinarian

Description	<i>A veterinary professional affiliated with one or more shelter branches. Manages animal health appointments, vaccination schedules, and medical records.</i>
Goals	• View and manage upcoming animal health appointments • Record vaccinations and update vaccination status and due dates • Access the universal health passport for any animal across shelter branches



Volunteer

Description	<i>A community member who supports shelter operations. Views assigned tasks, manages their schedule, and coordinates with shelter staff.</i>
Goals	• See assigned tasks and their status clearly • Manage their volunteering schedule • Contribute meaningfully to shelter operations without direct system admin access



Donor

Description	<i>An individual or organisation that contributes financially to one or more shelter branches. Manages their donation history and preferences.</i>
Goals	• Make donations to a specific shelter branch • View a history of past donations



Admin

Description	<i>A system administrator with organisation-wide access. Manages shelter data, user accounts, and has oversight of all operations across branches.</i>
Goals	• Manage shelter branch records including address and capacity • Oversee all user roles and system access • Monitor system health and inter-shelter transfers

2. Personas

2.1 Adopter

2.1.1a First-Time Adopter

- **Pain Points**
 - Inconsistent and time-consuming adoption procedures: Different shelters have different rules with no clear standard, leaving applicants confused. Excessive back-and-forth, slow responses, and multi-step approval chains deter first-time adopters.
 - Unreliable contact points: Unclear point of contact, no assigned staff or dedicated team who can continually assist with following up on applications.
 - Overly strict and arbitrary requirements: e.g. must have a fenced yard, no stairs allowed disqualify otherwise suitable adopters.
 - Unfamiliar with pet care: No assistance post adoption leading to incorrect or insufficient care towards pet, leading to returning pets back to shelters in worse cases, damaging pet health and adopter morale.
- **Artifacts**
 - [He Deserves the Best](#)
 - [\[Vent\] Adopting a dog is such a frustrating process](#)
 - [Shelter Adoption Process - why so difficult & time consuming?](#)
 - [Why adopt a dog is too difficult?](#)

2.1.1b Older / Senior Adopter

- **Pain Points**
 - Prone to online scams: Older adopters could fall prey to online pet scams due to fake listings or unverified websites that exploit unfamiliarity with digital channels.
 - Unfamiliar with technology: Navigating an online adoption process (forms, portals, account creation) is a barrier.
 - Physical limitations: Prevent some older adopters from visiting shelters multiple times in person to complete processes.
- **Artifacts**
 - [My grandma wants to get this dog online](#)
 - [Help! How do I ensure my grandma's not getting scammed?](#)

2.2 Shelter Staff

- **Pain Points**
 - Compassion fatigue is common to those who work in helping professions, often dealing with traumatic decisions such as euthanizing animals. They also may struggle with secondary trauma from witnessing animal abuse and neglect.
 - Many shelters are short staffed, with an influx of pets, leading to burnout. Most shelters have limited funding unable to provide good facilities for their employees.
 - Existing shelter management software is largely outdated, unintuitive, and siloed, unable to support modern workflows, cross-platform data sharing, or the diverse needs of both staff and adopters in one system.
- **Artifacts**
 - [Burnout & Compassion Fatigue in Animal Shelter Staff](#)
 - [Animal Shelter Software](#)
 - [Chameleon-CMS Software Review 2026: Features, Reviews, Integrations, Pros & Cons](#)

2.3 Veterinarian

- **Pain Points**
 - Fragmented and Paper-Based Medical Records: Most shelters have little to no digital medical infrastructure creating disorganized paper trails with missing history of a patient that slow down care and increase the risk of critical information being missed.
 - Balancing Population and Individual Care: Shelter vets must simultaneously manage the health of an entire animal population while addressing each animal's unique medical needs. This is further compounded by the emotional toll of collaborating with animal protection officers on neglect and abuse cases.
- **Artifacts**
 - [Veterinary Sector Spotlight: Shelter medicine](#)
 - [Stuck in old ways](#)

2.4 Volunteer

- **Pain Points**
 - Lack of Training for Inexperienced Volunteers: Many volunteers arrive eager to help but receive little to no structured onboarding. Without proper guidance on how to handle animals, new volunteers often feel lost and underprepared, reducing their effectiveness and increasing the risk of errors in animal care.
 - Disorganized Scheduling: Volunteer shifts are often managed through scattered emails, group chats, or paper sign-up sheets, making it difficult for volunteers to know when they are needed, what shifts are available, or whether their schedule has changed.
 - Limited Visibility into Volunteering Opportunities: Many potential volunteers are unaware of what shelter volunteering actually involves or what roles are available.
- **Artifacts**
 - [Not taking volunteers?](#)

2.5 Donor

- **Pain Points**
 - Lack of transparency on how donations are used: Donors give money but rarely receive meaningful updates on the impact of their contribution. Without this feedback loop, donors feel disconnected from the cause and are far less likely to give again.

2.6 Admin

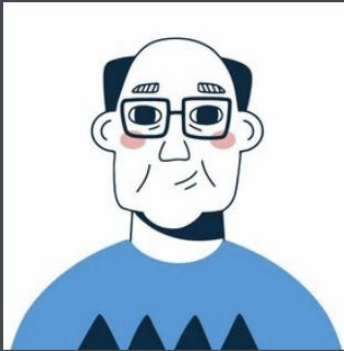
- **Pain Points**
 - Lack of a single source of truth across all shelters: Admins managing multiple shelter branches struggle most with the fact that every shelter operates in its own silo. This makes it nearly impossible to get a real-time, accurate picture of what's happening across the network at any given moment.

NAME

Arthur Brown

TYPE

Guardian



Demographic

♂ Male 74 years

📍 Macon, Georgia

Widowed

Retired Bank Clerk

Medium Income

Skills

Tech Savviness



Process Patience



Guidance Needed



Pet Care Knowledge



Mobility/Access to Shelter



Financial Planning



Scam Awareness



Adoption Experience



Persona

Older/Experienced Adopter

Goals

To eliminate loneliness and maintain an active lifestyle by adopting a dog.

Quote

“ Ever since Mary left, the house has gotten too quiet and there seems to be too much time on my hands. Of course I have my golf club buddies, but someone to light up the home would be nice. I don't mind the extra work, but he's gotta make me smile and keep me on my feet! ”

Background

Retired Bank Clerk now living in the suburbs of Georgia.

Recently lost his wife, his high-school sweetheart, married for 46 years. He is very close to his two daughters and their families who visit him at least 4 times a year. He remains very close to his old colleagues at the bank, and is an active member of the residential society committee.

He misses having company at home, and the silence can be difficult to deal with. He often feels afraid at night and deals with insomnia. His family and friends have suggested him to adopt a dog to help him feel safe, and keep him busy.

As someone who loves pets and has grown up with two dogs at home, he is very enthusiastic, but adoption centers are not accessible. The nearest animal shelter is 13 miles away and there is no public transport. He is advised not to drive by his doctor due to his arthritis. He is not very familiar with online adoption processes, but can manage the process with some assistance.

Motivations

- Wants a companion to fill the silence and loneliness after losing his wife.
- A dog would give him a daily routine and reason to stay active
- Family and friends have encouraged it, wants to make them feel at ease about his wellbeing
- Has prior experience with dogs growing up. Hence feels confident he can be a good owner
- Wants something to look forward to every day at home

Frustrations

- The nearest shelter is 13 miles away with no public transport access
- Doctor has advised against driving due to arthritis. Physically visits to shelters are inconvenient.
- Not very familiar with online processes and may need help navigating digital forms
- Small text, complex navigation, or too many steps online would make him give up
- Worried his age or living alone might cause his application to get rejected
- Uncertain about which dog breed would suit his energy level and living situation

NAME

Bryan Smith

TYPE

Artisan



Persona

Volunteer

Goals

Spare time to take care of animals in need and assist adoption centers.

Quote

I LOVE dogs, but unfortunately, mom is allergic to them. So the next best way to spend time with them is at my local shelter. I did submit an application last month, but I haven't got an update since. I really don't like bothering the staff about it because they already have their hands full. I'm also bit of an amateur, but I pick things up fast, so a bit of training would help me contribute effectively. Overall, I just want to be of help to the shelter and spend some time with the dogs... and maybe some cats too!

Demographic

♂ Male 18 years

📍 Chicago

Single

Student

Background

An 18-year-old college freshman from Chicago with a lifelong love for dogs. He grew up unable to have pets at home due to his mother's allergies, so volunteering at his local animal shelter became his way of staying connected to animals. He recently submitted a volunteer application but has not heard back, leaving him uncertain about next steps.

As a student, his schedule changes week to week depending on classes and assignments. He is enthusiastic and a quick learner but has no formal animal handling experience. He is considerate of the shelter staff's workload and avoids following up on his application because he doesn't want to be a burden, even though a simple status update would go a long way.

Skills

Tech Savviness



Availability & Commitment



Animal Handling Experience



Task Independence



Emotional Resilience



Motivations

- Wants to spend meaningful time with animals he can't have at home
- Feels a genuine desire to contribute to his local community
- Sees volunteering as an opportunity to gain hands-on experience with animals
- Wants to learn proper animal handling skills through structured training
- Hopes to make a real difference for shelter animals in his spare time

Frustrations

- No update on his volunteer application since submitting it a month ago
- No clear information on what tasks volunteers are expected to do
- Lacks structured onboarding or training to feel confident and prepared
- Unsure how to fit volunteering into a changing student schedule
- Feels hesitant to follow up with staff knowing how busy they already are

NAME

Charlotte Salazar

TYPE

Rational



Persona

Donor

Goals

Make impactful contributions to causes working towards animal and pet welfare.

Quote

"As an animal lover, I want to use my privilege to assist those who help them. Ever since my Duke [dog] left, it's been an annual tradition to donate a percentage of our profits to one animal welfare organization. But a recent conversation with my grand daughter sparked a thought, "Where can I see what our contribution has changed?" Understanding the impact would not only guide us toward more meaningful giving, but bring a deeper sense of fulfillment to something we already care so deeply about."

Demographic

Female 68 years

California

Married

Founder

Background

A 68-year-old founder based in California. Charlotte built her company over decades and has reached a stage in life where giving back has become a core part of her personal and professional identity. She has been an animal lover her entire life, and the loss of her dog Duke deepened her commitment to animal welfare causes.

She donates annually on behalf of her company, making it a tradition embedded in her business values. While she is warm and generous, she is also rational and results-driven by nature. She expects her contributions to be purposeful and well-directed. She relies on her granddaughter and personal assistant for most digital tasks, preferring simplicity and clarity when she does interact with online platforms herself.

Skills

Tech Savviness



Donation Frequency



Impact Awareness



Motivations

- Wants to honor Duke's memory through meaningful, ongoing contributions
- Believes those with financial privilege have a responsibility to support those who cannot help themselves
- Seeks the satisfaction of knowing her donations created a tangible, visible impact
- Wants to build a legacy of purposeful giving tied to her company's values

Frustrations

- No visibility into how donations are used or which animals were helped
- Receives little to no communication from organizations after donating
- Cannot easily track her donation history or generate records for her company's reporting
- Current donation platforms feel impersonal and transactional, no sense of connection to the cause

NAME

Emelie Archer

TYPE

Idealist



Demographic

Female 28 years

New York City

Single

Data Analyst

High income

Skills

Tech Savviness



Process Patience



Guidance Needed



Pet Care Knowledge



Mobility/Access to Shelter



Financial Planning



Scam Awareness



Adoption Experience



Persona

Young/First-Time Adopter

Goals

To make the most out of an independent youth in the big city, with a companion along side.

Quote

The only thing that's missing in my new studio is feline energy! I don't get off of work till 5 on most days, but shelters close by then. While I can't go to the shelter, I have no problem managing stuff online.

Background

Data Analyst at a financial firm.

A new graduate from Indiana University, living away from family for the first time in a big city. She was surrounded by many pets at home, including unconventional ones like turtles, a pigeon and even a racoon her father rescued.

Work is flexible, and she switches between working from office or home based on the project. At work, she takes initiative and her work style involves an organized approach with systematic documentation and communication. She sometimes has to work overtime and during weekends.

While living independently has been her dream, she wants more life in her apartment. Her hobbies include cooking and reading. She's part of a youth book club in her community who meet every weekend.

Motivations

- Grew up surrounded by pets and misses that energy living alone in a new city
- Wants a companion that fits her busy but flexible work schedule
- Feels ready for the responsibility of pet ownership as her first independent milestone
- Wants to give a shelter animal a home rather than buying from a breeder
- A pet would make her apartment feel more like a home

Frustrations

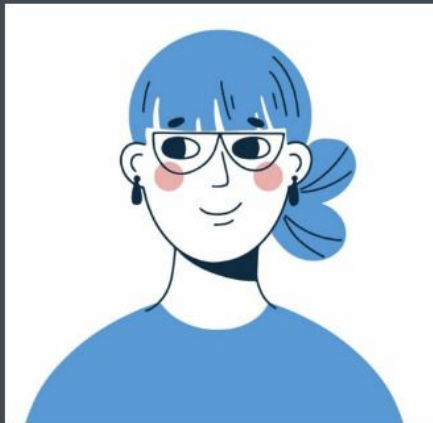
- Shelter visiting hours conflict with her 9-to-5 work schedule
- No centralized place to browse pets across multiple shelters in one city
- Adoption applications feel lengthy and unclear
- Doesn't know what to expect as a first-time owner in a small home alone.
- Hard to know if a cat's personality is a good fit for a small apartment without visiting in person

NAME

Isabella Martinez

TYPE

Idealist



Persona

Admin

Goals

Effectively manage shelter data and allot resources and work-load to ensure maximum efficiency.

Quote

As a government employee, I regularly work with multiple organizations. Without a centralized database or portal, it can get difficult to coordinate the different requests and allocate funds and assess capacity. As a result, I take more time to respond, and this unfortunately comes off as inefficiency in my performance.

Demographic

♀ Female 28 years

📍 Texas

Single

Associate Administration Developer

Medium Income

Background

A 28-year-old Associate Administration Developer working for a government animal welfare agency in Texas. Isabella is relatively early in her career but has quickly taken on significant responsibility acting as the central coordinator between multiple shelter branches, government bodies, and nonprofit organizations.

Her role requires her to manage shelter data, allocate funding, assess capacity across locations, and ensure compliance with government welfare standards. She is tech-comfortable and detail-oriented, but is constantly let down by the lack of a unified system forcing her to juggle emails, spreadsheets, and disconnected portals simultaneously. The inefficiency this creates reflects poorly on her performance, which frustrates her deeply given how hard she works.

Skills

Tech Savviness



Decision-Making Scope



Data Dependency



Collaboration with Other Roles



Motivations

- Wants a single centralized platform to manage all shelter data and requests in one place
- Aims to be recognized as an efficient, high-performing administrator
- Genuinely cares about improving animal welfare outcomes across the network
- Wants to make faster, more confident decisions backed by real-time data
- Hopes to modernize the way government-affiliated shelters operate

Frustrations

- No centralized system means coordinating across shelters relies on emails and manual tracking
- Difficulty assessing real-time capacity across multiple locations slows down critical decisions
- Delays in her responses are perceived as poor performance despite being caused by system inefficiencies
- Constantly switching between disconnected tools wastes significant time every day

NAME

Jay Asarathi

TYPE

Guardian



Persona

Veterinarian

Goals

To offer the best personalized medical treatment to shelter animals.

Quote

As a passionate animal medicine specialist, I'm fortunate to serve the less fortunate, which started all the way from my home town's local shelter, to one of the biggest animal adoption centers in the state. I'd love to have more context and organization when it comes to the medical history of our patients, to be able to serve these voiceless angels in the best way.

Demographic

♂ Male 43 years

📍 California

Married

Veterinarian

High income

Background

Veterinarian with a specialization in animal orthopedics.

A veterinarian with a specialization in animal orthopedics, working at one of California's largest animal adoption centers. He began his career at a small local shelter and has spent 15+ years working his way up through the shelter medicine system. Despite his specialized expertise, the high-volume nature of shelter work means he rarely gets to apply deep clinical focus, instead managing a constant flow of animals with varying and often undocumented medical histories.

He is deeply committed to giving every shelter animal the same quality of care he would give a private patient, but is frequently held back by disorganized, paper-based record systems that make it difficult to understand an animal's full medical background before treating them.

Skills

Tech Savviness



Data Entry Frequency



Decision-Making Speed



Emotional Resilience



Collaboration with Other Roles



Motivations

- Wants complete, organized medical histories for every animal before making treatment decisions
- Believes every shelter animal deserves personalized, high-quality medical care regardless of their background
- Wants to reduce time spent hunting for records so he can spend more time on actual clinical work
- Feels a strong sense of purpose serving animals who have no voice of their own

Frustrations

- Incomplete or missing medical histories make it hard to provide safe, informed treatment
- Paper-based records from external vets are slow to arrive, easy to lose, and hard to reference quickly
- High animal volume leaves little time for thorough individual assessments
- No centralized system to track vaccination schedules, treatment history, or upcoming medical due dates across the entire shelter population

NAME

Sasha Nellie Grey

TYPE

Artisan



Goals

To make the administrative side of shelter operations low maintained so that she can redirect her time and energy toward caring for animals and connect them with the right families.

Persona

Shelter Staff

Quote

“Working with animals has been my lifelong passion. I'm naturally great with bonding and understanding them. Like children, they just require patience and kindness which is often missing from their lives. I don't know what I'm doing wrong, because I feel burnout, not from the work itself, but with the administration part of it. Some things are just too time consuming, and there's only so much one person can do.”

Demographic

Female 36 years

Denver

Single

Associate

Medium Income

Background

An experienced shelter worker with a background in social work.

She has spent over 10 years working across two different shelters in Denver, starting as a volunteer before transitioning into a full-time staff role. Her social work background means she approaches both animals and adopters with empathy and patience.

She manages a wide range of daily responsibilities — from updating animal profiles and reviewing adoption applications to coordinating volunteers and assisting with fundraising events. Despite her passion for the work, she finds the administrative side increasingly overwhelming, often staying late to catch up on data entry and paperwork that the current system makes unnecessarily tedious.

She is not particularly tech-savvy but is willing to learn tools that genuinely make her job easier. She has used two different shelter management systems and found both frustrating in different ways.

Skills

Tech Savviness



Multitasking Ability



Data Entry Frequency



Collaboration with Other Roles



Motivations

- Wants to see every animal in her care find a safe, loving home
- Believes a well-run shelter directly saves more animal lives
- Wants to spend more time with the animals and less time on administrative tasks
- Takes pride in building genuine relationships with adopters and volunteers
- Hopes to eventually move into a shelter management or policy role

Frustrations

- Current software is outdated and requires repetitive, manual data entry
- No unified system switches between spreadsheets, emails, and software constantly
- Unable to achieve uniform distribution of animals across shelters
- Feels burnt out not from caring for animals but from the weight of administrative inefficiency